

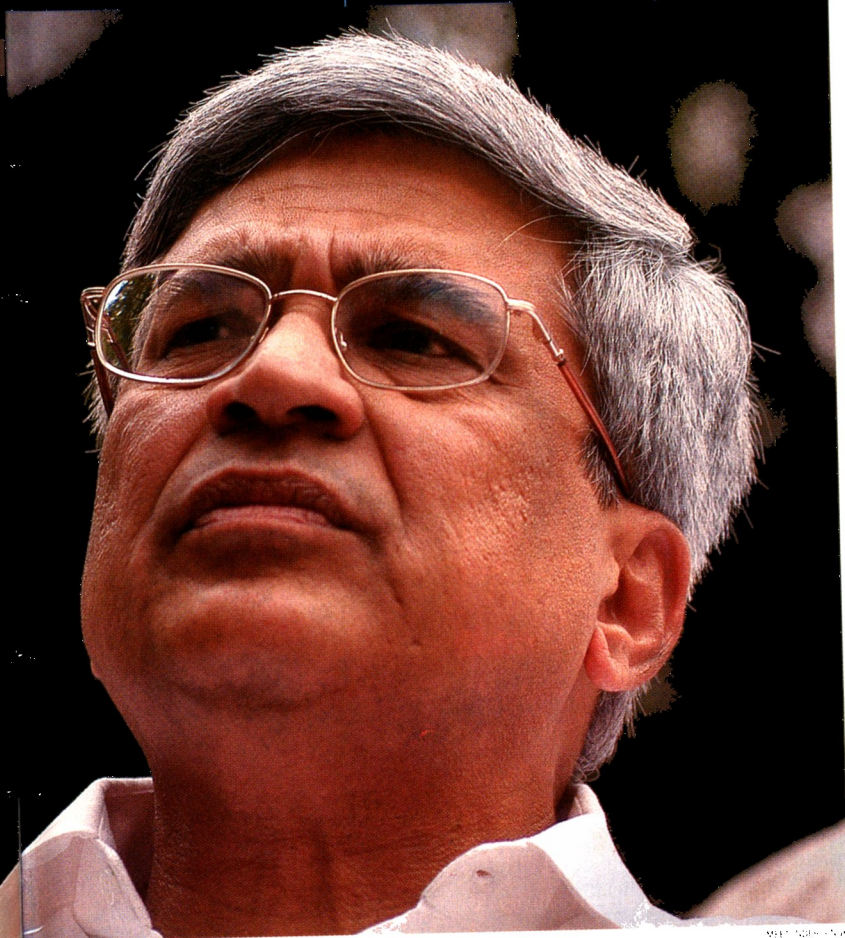
OCT 2, 2007 A strategic partnership with the US can't go hand-in-hand with the commitment of pursuing an independent foreign policy. The deal can't be seen in isolation of such a partnership.

OCT 5, 2007 The fact that waivers under Section 104 will cease to be ineffective if India detonated a nuclear device shows that India has not been recognised as a nuclear weapons state.

OCT 20, 2007 The assertion in the UPA's note that the agreement "gives equal rights to both parties to seek termination" is irrelevant, as the issue is to bind the US to its commitments as a supplier.

OCT 22, 2007 The Left believes that the Common Minimum Programme should guide the foreign policy of the Government, rather than subjective perceptions of "national interests".

Source: The Left notes to the UPA Government on the India-US nuclear deal



have also been able to slow down the pace of implementation of neo-liberal policies," he had said, with fierce pride, in the organisational report in April. His critics charge him with the lack of political skill to script a working arrangement with the UPA Government, while continuously blocking the UPA's reform initiatives. Yet, though many moan the iron-clad ideologue, Karat has restored the Left's pet concerns to the mainstream from where they had been banished by the market-driven din and Surjeet's somewhat flexible interpretation of communist dogma.

Within the party though, many insiders feel Karat has failed to steer political debate over controversial issues to help the organisation grow. His dissent notes to government policies may have been vehemently worded but they did not articulate a coherent ideological perspective. While leaders like E.M.S. Namboodiripad wrote reams defining the party's ideology in relation to contemporary issues, Karat's legacy may well be the literature he has generated on arcane details like pension reforms. He has also come under attack from his own colleagues for "outsourcing opinion" to Left intellectuals on vital issues like external loans for Left-led governments. It hasn't helped that his much-hyped Hindi-heartland plans are yet to take off. Instead of rising, the party membership in Uttar Pradesh fell from 6,346 in 2006 to 6,175 in 2007, while in Punjab it fell from 10,508 in 2006 to 10,140 last year.

With the party now at pains to explain a possible future scenario where the Congress may seek its support to stop the BJP from coming back to power, Karat seems to have lost his golden boy sheen. And while he is not headed irrevocably for the exit, it may well be that when the Marxists make their habitual appraisal of current events a few years down the line, this will be yet another historic blunder on the Red Brigade's road to redemption. ■

celebrations, Karat has a free run over the party's affairs. West Bengal Chief Minister Buddhadeb Bhattacharya has been lying low since the Nandigram fiasco while Kerala Chief Minister V.S. Achuthanandan is busy securing his turf in a factional feud. But it cannot be denied that his primal instinct—that of protecting the "Left-leaning votebank" in the two states—has kept the party relevant in India long after the world has booted out communism. Even Karat's staunchest critics can't deny the ferocity with which he had successfully prevented any reforms that pro-market advocates may have wanted to pursue

FULL MARX: Karat blocked UPA's market-led reforms at every point

in the 49 months of the UPA's rule.

"It was the firm stand of the party and the Left which prevented a full-fledged entry of FDI in retail trade, the opening up of the private banking sector to 74 per cent FDI and stopped a legislation which would have allowed privatisation of government employees' pension funds. We can claim that we have checked some of the harmful measures and retrograde policies which the Government wanted to pursue in the name of reforms. Further, we